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Teacher Guide

Level: College • Introductory Psychology

Standard / objective: Course objective — Distinguish research designs, identify variables and bias, interpret correlation cautiously, and apply core human-subject protections.

Source / course note: Course-level objective; no accreditation or universal equivalency claimed.

Before this lesson: Distinguish a measured outcome from a proposed explanation.

Model and discuss: In a randomized fictional experiment comparing quiet and music study conditions, sound condition is the independent variable and quiz score is the dependent variable.

Watch for: Random assignment supports group comparability; random sampling supports population representation. They serve different purposes.

Suggested sequence: 5-minute launch, 10-minute model, 20-30 minutes of practice, then a 5-minute exit ticket. Use separate paper for extended writing.

Learning supports

AIG: Identify a confound and redesign the study to reduce it.

504: Offer chunked tasks, reduced copying, extra time, and breaks as specified in the learner's plan.

EC: Sort short examples into manipulated variable, measured outcome, and uncontrolled factor.

ESL: Rehearse: The researchers change ___ and measure ___. This design can/cannot ___.

Adapt these suggestions to the current learning plan. Print on US Letter paper at actual size; keep the key separate. One teacher may use the resource with their own students; no public posting or resale.



Student Directions & Practice

Evaluate fictional studies without confusing correlation and causation.

Directions: Complete every item. Show work or cite evidence. For open responses, answer in complete sentences.

- 1.** Define independent variable.
- 2.** Define dependent variable.
- 3.** What design best tests cause and effect?
- 4.** A correlation is $r = -0.78$. Describe direction and strength.
- 5.** Does correlation prove causation?
- 6.** Identify bias in a voluntary online poll.
- 7.** Why use random assignment?
- 8.** Name two protections for human participants.



Assessment / Exit Ticket

Work independently. Show your reasoning. Use extra paper if needed.

1. Students choose whether to attend tutoring. Attendees score higher. Does this prove tutoring caused higher scores? Explain.

2. For a randomized study of quiet versus music, identify the independent and dependent variables if the outcome is quiz score.

Reflection: What helped you decide? What do you want to practice next?

Score each task: 2 = accurate with clear reasoning; 1 = partly correct or missing reasoning; 0 = incorrect or no evidence. The reflection is not scored.

Answer Key & Teaching Guidance

1. The variable manipulated by the researcher.
2. The measured outcome.
3. A controlled experiment with appropriate assignment.
4. Strong negative association.
5. No; third variables and directionality remain possible.
6. Voluntary-response/self-selection bias.
7. To reduce systematic preexisting differences between groups.
8. Examples: informed consent, minimized risk, privacy, right to withdraw, debriefing.

Exit ticket guidance

1. No. Self-selection and other differences, such as motivation or prior knowledge, may explain the association.
2. Independent variable: sound condition. Dependent variable: quiz score.

Next teaching move: Use the worked model again if the concept is unclear. If the answer is correct but reasoning is incomplete, ask for an explanation. Offer the extension once both tasks are secure. Scores guide instruction; they are not standardized mastery cutoffs.